

Unit 3 Review of Related Literature

3.1 Conducting a Literature Review: Systematic Review and Thematic Review

Literature Review

A thematic review is a type of literature review that involves identifying, analyzing, and organizing existing research based on recurring themes, patterns, or concepts across studies. A literature review critically examines existing research related to a specific topic, providing a foundation for new research by identifying gaps and building on previous knowledge.

1. Systematic Review

A systematic review uses a predefined protocol to search for, select, assess, and synthesize research evidence. It aims to minimize bias by applying transparent and reproducible methods. A structured and comprehensive approach to identify, evaluate, and synthesize all relevant studies on a specific research question using predefined criteria.

- **Characteristics:**

- Uses explicit, transparent, and replicable methods.
- Involves rigorous searching of multiple databases.
- Applies inclusion and exclusion criteria to select studies.
- Often includes quality assessment of studies.
- Summarizes findings quantitatively (sometimes via meta-analysis) or qualitatively.

- **Purpose:**

To minimize bias and provide reliable, evidence-based conclusions.

2. Thematic Review

A thematic review is a qualitative approach to literature review that involves identifying, organizing, and analyzing key themes, patterns, or recurring ideas across various research studies. Instead of summarizing each study individually, this method clusters findings around themes that emerge from the collective literature.

- **Characteristics:**

- Focuses on identifying, analyzing, and reporting themes within the literature.
- Less rigid than systematic review, allowing flexibility in synthesis.
- Helps to understand concepts, theories, and ideas across different studies.
- Emphasizes depth of understanding rather than exhaustive search.

- **Purpose:**

To explore and interpret patterns and meanings in existing research, providing insight into the topic.

3.2 Developing a Conceptual Framework

A conceptual framework is a structured plan that outlines the key concepts, variables, and the relationships among them in a study. It acts as a guide for the research by visually or descriptively explaining how the researcher thinks the problem will be explored.

A conceptual framework is a visual or narrative representation of the main concepts, theories, and variables involved in the research, showing how they relate to each other.

Purpose:

- To clarify the **research focus**.
- To identify **key variables** and **constructs**.
- To illustrate **hypothesized relationships** between variables.
- To provide a **logical structure** for collecting and interpreting data.

Steps to Develop a Conceptual Framework:

1. Identify the Research Problem:

- Clearly define the issue or question your research addresses.

2. Review the Literature:

- Examine existing theories and findings related to your topic.

3. Select Key Variables or Constructs:

- Identify the **independent, dependent**, and possibly **moderating or mediating variables**.

4. Define Relationships:

- Explain how the variables are connected (e.g., cause-effect, correlation, influence).

5. Draw the Framework:

- Create a **diagram or model** showing the variables and their relationships, or describe it in writing.

Example (in Education Research):

Topic: Effect of Parental Involvement on Student Achievement

- Independent Variable: Parental involvement

- Dependent Variable: Student academic performance
- Mediating Variable: Student motivation

3.3 Verification of Authentic Sources and Integrating Findings

1. Verification of Authentic Sources

Ensuring that the sources used in research are **credible, reliable, and scholarly** is crucial for maintaining academic integrity and producing valid results.

Criteria for Verifying Authentic Sources:

- **Author Credentials:** The author should be an expert in the field (e.g., academic, researcher, professional).
- **Publication Type:** Prefer peer-reviewed journals, books from academic publishers, and government or institutional reports.
- **Publisher Reputation:** Check if the source is published by a recognized university press or reputable organization.
- **Date of Publication:** Use recent sources unless citing historical context. Outdated data may not reflect current knowledge.
- **Citations:** Reliable sources are often well-cited by other scholars.
- **Domain Check for Websites:** Trust domains like .edu, .gov, or .org over commercial sites (.com).

Tools and Databases for Verifying Sources:

- **Google Scholar:** <https://scholar.google.com>
- **PubMed (Health & Life Sciences):** <https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov>
- **ERIC (Education):** <https://eric.ed.gov>
- **ResearchGate:** <https://www.researchgate.net>
- **Scopus / Web of Science** (for indexing and impact factor)

2. Integrating Findings

Once reliable sources are verified, findings need to be organized and synthesized to support your research objectives or questions.

Steps to Integrate Findings:

1. **Organize by Theme or Concept:**

- Group findings under thematic headings to see patterns or contradictions.

2. Summarize Key Points:

- Paraphrase main ideas from different sources while maintaining the original meaning.

3. Compare and Contrast Studies:

- Note agreements, conflicts, and trends among researchers.

4. Cite Appropriately:

- Use a consistent citation style (APA, MLA, etc.) to acknowledge sources.

5. Relate to Your Study:

- Show how each finding connects to your research question or framework.